it has been thought, from the favour with which Boaz's marriage with Ruth is regarded in the Book, that it was written as a protest against the line taken by these two reformers. But this cannot be considered probable; nor can the present writer, at any rate, satisfy himself that the Book is as late as the 5th cent. B.C. It is, however, not impossible, considering the prominence given to this subject in c. 3—4, that it is a collateral *didactic* aim of the author to inculcate the duty of marriage on the part of the next-of-kin[1] with a widow left childless.

*Date of Composition.*—Most modern critics consider Ruth to be exilic (Ew. *Hist.* i. 154 f.), or post-exilic (Berth. Wellh. Kuen. &c.); the chief grounds alleged being (1) the learned, antiquarian interest which is thought to manifest itself in 4, 1–12, pointing in particular to the time when the custom referred to in *v.* 7 had become obsolete; and (2) the language, which exhibits some Aramaisms and other late expressions.

It is doubtful whether these grounds are decisive. The general Hebrew style (the idioms and the syntax) shows no marks of deterioration: it is palpably different, not merely from that of Esther and Chronicles, but even from Nehemiah's memoirs or Jonah, and stands on a level with the best parts of Samuel.[2]

The linguistic traits alluded to are the 2nd fem. sing. impf. in יִ-, 2, 8. 21. 3, 4. 18 (elsewhere only Is. 45, 10. Jer. 31, 22. 1 Sa. 1, 14), and the 2nd fem. sing. pf. in תִּי- 3, 3. 4 (elsewhere only in Mic. 4, 13; Jer. [frequently]; Ez. 16[3]): these, however, are in fact the original terminations, which may have remained in use locally (cf. אִתִּי, כִּי-, p. 178, *note*), and, as the parallels quoted show, are, at least, not confined to *post*-exilic authors. Further—

לָהֵן *therefore* 1, 13 (as in Aram., Dan. 2, 6. 9. 4, 24).

[1] Not the duty of the *levirate*-marriage (Gen. 38; Dt. 25, 5). Boaz is not Ruth's *brother-in-law*.

[2] The whole style is classical; but among particular idioms notice 1, 17 כה יעשה י"י לי וגו׳ (elsewhere only in Sam. Kgs.: p. 174); 1, 19 ותהם כל העיר (1 Ki. 1, 45); 2, 21 עד אם (only besides Gen. 24, 19 J. Is. 30, 17); 4, 4 גלה אזן (as 1 Sa. 9, 15. 20, 2. 12, 13. 22, 8. 17. 2 Sa. 7, 27); and esp. 2, 8 כה *here*, in the *local* sense, elsewhere only in JE (Gen. 22, 5. 31, 37. Ex. 2, 12. Nu. 11, 31. 23, 15) and 2 Sa. 18, 30, which is not a trait likely to have been *imitated* by a later writer. The suff. באנה 1, 19 is paralleled also in E (Gen. 21, 29. 42, 36).

[3] This very peculiar distribution of an anomalous form—in books neither specially early nor specially late, and in *one* chapter only of a long book—must be due, in some measure, to accidental causes.